Philosophy 25A: Ancient Philosophy

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Topic 4

Plato's Infantile Misunderstanding

In his dialogue *Phaedo*, Plato establishes the universal concept of Forms for his metaphysical system of being and knowledge without realizing that his theory is flawed by a misunderstanding of certain linguistic foundations. I seek to reconstruct Plato's argument through the premises that support it, and then elaborate further on what I suppose to be the strongest objection to Plato's theory. First, I will explain what Plato's theory of Forms is. Next, I will iterate over the properties of Forms relevant to the argument. Then, I will reconstruct Plato's argument for the simultaneous participation in opposite Forms. Following this, I will offer a clarifying analogy to Plato's theory to eliminate irrelevant details. Finally, I will explain my objection to Plato's theory of Forms and attack the soundness of his argument, concluding with a possible remedy to change the definition of what Form is.

Plato creates the framework for the relationship between his metaphysical Forms and our visible reality through his Allegory of the Cave (Republic, 514a-520a). He claims that the Forms exist in a realm separate from the material world. This realm and the Forms within it are eternal, unchanging, and immaterial. In this way, Forms are standard ideas in which all material things participate. Each Form is the pure idea of the object itself. Plato explains this relationship through his example of "equality" (Phaedo, 74a-75e). Plato asserts that we can never perceive with our senses the pure Form of "equality." In other words, we can never encounter pure

“equality” in anything material, such as seemingly equal-length logs. We perceive “equality” with our mind by accessing the Form of “equality” which exists in the realm of Forms.

To further specify the use of Forms as pure concepts, Plato defines the nature of Forms (Phaedo, 96a-103a). He first describes how the participation of material things in their respective Forms causes these material things to emerge in reality. He then rationalizes that if there is a Form to make things come to be, then there must also be an opposite to that Form to reverse it. For example, doubling the value of one causes the value of two to come to be, and inversely halving the value of two causes the value of one to come to be (Phaedo, 97a). Plato concludes that each higher Form has an opposite, Forms can never become their opposite, Forms can never mix with their opposite, and things cannot participate in opposite Forms at the same time. Plato also concludes that particular Forms, such as that of an apple, have a unique essence that encapsulates their Form, such as the apple’s apple-ness. This crucial distinction allows Plato to sort participation in Forms into categories: pertaining to essence, and not pertaining to essence. For example, snow must participate in the Form of coldness – this participation is essential to its nature. Tea, on the other hand, can participate in both the Form of coldness at one point and the Form of hotness at another. Temperature is not part of the essence of tea. Plato reconciles an object partaking in opposite Forms, such as tea of varying temperatures, by insisting that an object can only partake in one of those Forms at a time – as one Form becomes more present, the opposite Form retreats.

Based on these definitions, Plato arrives at the conclusion that an object can participate in contradictory Forms. In his dialogue *Phaedo*, Plato provides the following argument as to how this is possible:

1. Participation in the Form of shortness retreats as Simmias is compared to Socrates, and participation in the Form of tallness comes forth.
2. Simmias is tall when viewed relative to Socrates, so Simmias participates in tallness.
3. Participation in the Form of tallness retreats as Simmias is compared to Phaedo, and participation in the Form of shortness comes forth.
4. Simmias is short when viewed relative to Phaedo, so Simmias participates in shortness

C. Simmias is both tall and short.

The argument presented by Plato is valid, but it is not sound. This is because Plato slips from non-essential to essential definitions of participation in Forms over the course of the argument. Height is not an essence of any of the particular people used in the argument. Simmias' height is not necessarily an essential part of his Simmias-ness, yet the conclusion presents it as essential. However, because this objection slips into the murky territory of Simmias' identity and what makes Simmias himself, I will propose a clarifying example:

> Suppose line B is greater than line A and less than line C. Line B's participation in "greatness" is given to be essential, as well as line B's participation in "lessness." Therefore, line B participates in opposite Forms at once.
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> Furthermore, suppose line B is double the length of line A and half the length of line C. Again, line B's participation in the Form of "double" is essential, as well as line B's participation in the Form of "half." Therefore, line B participates in opposite Forms at once.

The comparative nature of line B requires its participation in opposite forms to be essential to its existence. This example is nearly identical to that of Plato's, but it clearly states that the identity of the lines is predicated on their relationship to one another, eliminating slipping between definitions. Despite this clarification, however, the argument remains unsound due to the nature of relative terms.

Relative Forms are Forms that require a comparison to be validated. Objects that participate in Forms such as "hotness," "greatness," and "equality" are required to be compared to other objects or an observer's relative perception. For example, Forms of "greatness" and "smallness" do not emerge until the required comparison is made. This is problematic because Forms cause objects to emerge in reality, not the other way around. These qualities, then, do not belong to the objects themselves, but rather only exist within the observer's mind/soul. Therefore, Simmias is, for himself, neither short nor tall. These are linguistic expressions that do not correspond to Simmias in and of himself. Plato fails to recognize that comparative expressions cannot be made in isolation. The expression "Simmias is both tall and short" isolates the object, Simmias, from the people he was being compared to. Perhaps instead of allowing the comparative existence of opposite Forms, Plato can reconcile his framework by eliminating opposite Forms and treating adjective Forms as a value concept. Objects can then be said to participate in unpaired, positive Forms to varying degrees, such as Simmias participating in a degree of tallness.